



PROPOSAL FOR INTERIM COMMUNITY USE

7704 S. Stony Island Avenue

A short-term license that keeps your property secure, maintained and active as a Caribbean cultural venue until your redevelopment is ready to begin.

PREPARED FOR

South Side Studios Ventures LLC
(formerly Regal Mile Ventures LLC)
Attn: James Reynolds Jr., Manager
425 South Financial Place, Suite 2700
Chicago, IL 60605

PREPARED BY

Stephen Henry, Founder
Caribbean Cultural Center
Yawd LLC d/b/a Caribbean Cultural Center
765 E. 154th St., South Holland, IL 60473
414-909-3279 • stephen@selassiefest.com

The request in one page

Your property at 7704 S. Stony Island Avenue (PIN 20-26-423-001-0000) is part of a larger redevelopment. Until construction begins, it sits vacant. We propose to put that time to work for you and for the neighborhood.

What we ask: a short-term, revocable license to use the property for permitted cultural and community programming, ending on agreed notice from you.

What we offer: we take on the cost, upkeep, security and insurance of an active site, and we leave it clean whenever you are ready to build.

What the owner gets

- **An occupied, watched site** instead of a vacant one, which means less dumping, trespass, vandalism and code exposure.
- **No cost.** We pay for maintenance, security, waste removal, utilities we use, permits and insurance.
- **Liability protection.** You are named as additional insured on our policy, and we indemnify you for our use.
- **Full control and an easy exit.** This is a license, not a lease. It creates no tenancy and no interest in the property, and it ends on your notice.
- **Goodwill on the corridor before you build.** Neighbors and the city see the site cared for and used, and if you wish, you are recognized as the partner who made it possible.
- **Flexibility.** You keep access at all times for surveys, inspections and pre-construction work.

Why a Caribbean cultural center

Chicago has dedicated cultural buildings for dozens of communities, but in our survey of 66 enclaves and cultural centers we found none for the English-speaking Caribbean: Jamaican, Trinidadian, Guyanese, Barbadian, Bahamian, Belizean and others. Community leaders cited by the Encyclopedia of Chicago estimated 40,000 to 50,000 Jamaicans in the area alone. Those communities gather at festivals, but have no permanent home. This site can be that home for a season or more, while we work toward a permanent location.

The next step

A 30-minute meeting and site walk with you or your representative. We will bring a draft license agreement for your counsel to review.

A simple license, written to protect the owner

These terms are a starting point for discussion, not a binding offer. Final terms would be set out in a written agreement reviewed by both parties' counsel.

Parties	South Side Studios Ventures LLC ("Owner") and Yawd LLC d/b/a Caribbean Cultural Center ("Licensee"), with Ras Tafari Inc., a 501(c)(3) public charity, as programming partner.
Premises	7704 S. Stony Island Ave., Chicago, IL 60649 (PIN 20-26-423-001-0000), plus any adjoining parcels the Owner chooses to include. Outdoor areas first. The 1927 building would be used only after inspection and with the Owner's written approval.
Nature of right	Revocable license only. No lease, tenancy, leasehold or other interest in the property. Licensee waives any claim to relocation assistance or compensation when the license ends.
Term	Starts on signing and continues month to month until ended by either party.
Notice to vacate	60 days' written notice from the Owner (proposed; open to discussion). Licensee removes all of its property and leaves the site clean before the end date.
Fee	Nominal license fee of \$1 per year, or as agreed. Licensee bears all costs of its use.
Permitted use	Cultural, educational and community programming: markets, classes, exhibits, fitness, youth and elder programs, and permitted public events. All public events held under the required City of Chicago permits and licenses.
Insurance	Commercial general liability of at least \$1,000,000 per occurrence and \$2,000,000 aggregate, with the Owner named as additional insured. Liquor liability if alcohol is ever served. Certificate delivered before any use.
Indemnity	Licensee indemnifies, defends and holds the Owner harmless from claims arising from Licensee's use of the premises.
Maintenance & security	Licensee keeps the site clean, secured and free of dumping and graffiti; handles snow and litter on adjoining sidewalks; and reports any damage promptly.
Alterations	Temporary, removable installations only (tents, staging, planters, fencing, signage). Nothing structural and no utility changes without the Owner's written approval and permits.
Owner access	Owner and its consultants may enter at any time for inspection, surveys, testing and pre-construction work.
Neighbors	Published hours, sound limits measured at the property line, litter patrols and a resident contact line with logged responses.
Signage	Owner approves exterior signage. Owner's project or "future home of" signage may be displayed at no charge.
Restoration	When the license ends, Licensee returns the site broom-clean and in at least the condition it was received.

The Yawd: a permanent identity with changeable programming

"Yawd" is Jamaican for yard, or home. The venue keeps one recognizable look (gateway, stage, market row and community row) while each day's or weekend's program changes the signage, food and music inside it. Every element is temporary and removable.

Gateway & box office. Entry, check-in, security and guest information.

Market row. Caribbean food, Ital and breakfast stalls, crafts and retail.

The commons. Open central floor for dancing, dining, classes and competitions.

Main stage. Live music, DJs, fitness classes, talks and film.

Community row. Culture House exhibits, Selecta Academy, wellness and play.

Dominoes & oldies yard. Elders' tables, tournaments and storytelling.

Concept renderings are available in the full-color edition of this proposal.

One venue, many celebrations

- SelassieFest; Jamaica 65 (Jamaican Independence, August 2027); Marcus Garvey Festival
- Country days: Belize Day; Trinidad & Tobago Independence Fest
- Food: Jerk Fest; Ackee 'n' R&B breakfast; weekly market
- Community: Gospel Sundays; domino tournaments; Lickle Pickney family days; ReggaeRobics fitness; Chicago House Music Takeover

A typical week

Mon	Dark day: maintenance, rehearsals, community production lab
Tue – Thu	Morning fitness and wellness; midday market and heritage exhibits; afternoon youth and elders programs; evening film, poetry or a resident band
Fri	Diaspora Friday: a country or city takeover
Sat	Full-site festival day (the celebrations above)
Sun	Gospel, brunch, family and oldies programming

Run safely, opened in stages, handed back on time

Safety and compliance

- City of Chicago special event, food vendor and amplified-sound permits for every public event
- Licensed security and a first-aid plan scaled to each event
- Clear, lit exits that no tent, queue or vendor may block
- Written weather rules: activity stops for lightning, high wind, extreme heat or poor air quality
- Health-department-compliant food service and handwashing stations
- Fire extinguishers at every cooking station; cooking kept to a separate service edge

Daily routine

- Pre-opening walk-through: site, exits, electrical, sanitation, accessibility
- Opening only after a signed readiness check
- Ongoing weather and crowd monitoring
- Post-close sweep of the site and adjoining sidewalks
- Overnight lock-up and incident log, available to the Owner on request

Good neighbor commitments

- Event dates and sound checks posted in advance
- Deliveries and teardown within approved hours
- A named contact for residents and businesses

Phasing

1. **Agree.** Meet, walk the site, sign the license and deliver the insurance certificate.
2. **Stabilize.** Clean-up, debris removal, securing the perimeter, and safety and code review of the site. No public use yet.
3. **Open small.** Low-impact, permitted programs: markets, classes, exhibits and community meetings.
4. **Season.** Full programming for the 2027 outdoor season (late May through Labor Day), coordinated with SelassieFest.
5. **Hand back.** On the Owner's notice, wind down, remove everything and return the site clean.

The people behind the proposal

Caribbean Cultural Center is being organized as Yawd LLC, doing business as Caribbean Cultural Center. Its mission is to give Chicago's Caribbean communities a cultural home built on unity, heritage and community.

Stephen Henry, founder, is President of **Ras Tafari Inc.**, a 501(c)(3) public charity and the producer of SelassieFest, a roots reggae and cultural festival. Ras Tafari Inc. would serve as the programming partner for nonprofit and community activities on the site.

More about the plan: selassiefest.com/ccc

7 · NEXT STEPS

What we propose happens next

1. A 30-minute meeting and site walk with the Owner or its representative.
2. We send a draft license agreement based on these terms, for the Owner's counsel to revise.
3. Once signed and insured, we begin stabilizing the site, with no public use until permits are in place.

Contact: Stephen Henry · 414-909-3279 · stephen@selassiefest.com
765 E. 154th St., South Holland, IL 60473

Interest in proceeding (non-binding)

Signing below indicates only interest in discussing a license on the general lines of this proposal. It creates no obligation on either party; any agreement must be in a separate signed writing.

For South Side Studios Ventures LLC
Name / title / date

Stephen Henry, for Caribbean Cultural Center
Date